

Musical periods

Music styles through history

From the earliest times humans have made music, first with the voice, then by adding simple instruments. In the early medieval period, music took on a more formal structure as plainchant came into use in churches and multiple voices singing at once marked the beginning of harmony. From the late Middle Ages onward, the history of music is divided into distinct periods, each with its own musical style.

RENAISSANCE 1400–1600

Feature	Explanation	Key composers/works
Polyphony, meaning many voices, is the most important form of sacred choral music.	Vocal lines imitate one another, weaving a complex musical tapestry of sound, heard at its best in the vast spaces of a church.	Thomas Tallis, <i>Spem in alium</i> ; William Byrd, <i>Mass for five voices</i> ; Giovanni Pierluigi di Palestrina, <i>Missa Papae Marcelli</i>
The madrigal, an unaccompanied part song for several voices, becomes popular in Italy and England.	Written for two to eight solo voices, madrigals often use texts based on love and death, or pastoral topics.	Carlo Gesualdo, “Moro, lasso, al mio duolo”; Thomas Morley, “It was a lover and his lass”; Orlando Gibbons, “The Silver Swan”
The lute becomes a favorite instrument for solos, and as a vocal accompaniment.	The quietly expressive lute gained popularity throughout Europe. The lute song was a successful English creation.	John Dowland, “Flow my tears”; Thomas Campion, <i>Books of Ayres</i>

BAROQUE 1600–1750

Feature	Explanation	Key composers/works
Opera is born in Italy and catches on quickly, especially in France and, later, England.	Emerging from Florence around 1600, opera is the result of adding music to make stories more dramatic.	Claudio Monteverdi, <i>Orfeo</i> ; Henry Purcell, <i>Dido and Aeneas</i> ; George Frideric Handel, <i>Xerxes</i>
Rise of instrumental works, as interest in instrument manufacture increases.	Development of three-movement trio sonata (quick-slow-lively), featuring solo instrument and continuos.	Arcangelo Corelli, <i>Concerto Grossi</i> ; Antonio Vivaldi, <i>The Four Seasons</i> ; George Frideric Handel, <i>Water Music</i>
Continuo binds together musical ensembles.	A bass instrument and keyboard play chords indicated by “shorthand” figures.	Continuo is heard in instrumental and vocal ensembles throughout the period.
Early orchestra takes shape.	Typical ensemble includes strings, oboes, bassoons, and continuo.	Johann Sebastian Bach, <i>Orchestral suites</i>
Keys and key signatures become established.	Composers use harmony as a structural element of works.	Johann Sebastian Bach, <i>48 Preludes and Fugues</i>

CLASSICAL 1750–1820

Feature	Explanation	Key composers/works
Sonata principle (forms) established as a useful structure.	Three-part sonata form consists of exposition, development, and recapitulation.	Features widely as basis for first movements of sonatas, symphonies, and concertos.
Symphony becomes the favorite form for orchestral music.	Four-movement structure is established: fast-slow-dance-lively.	Josef Haydn, <i>Symphony no 100</i> ; Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart, <i>Symphony no 41</i>
Development of the orchestra—notably at Mannheim, which has a famously musical Court.	The modern symphony orchestra emerges with strings, flutes, oboes, clarinets, bassoons, horns, trumpets, and drums.	Johann Stamitz, <i>Symphony in E♭ major</i>
Instruments are made simpler to play in every key.	Composers can write music of greater technical difficulty in more extreme keys.	Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart, <i>Horn Concerto no 3</i> ; Ludwig van Beethoven, “Spring” violin sonata
Chamber music, especially the string quartet, features prominently.	Most famous composers, notably Haydn and Mozart, played quartets with friends.	Josef Haydn, <i>Quartets op 76</i> ; Ludwig van Beethoven, <i>Quartet op 131</i> ; Franz Schubert, <i>Piano trio no 1</i>